Biden to meet with George Floyd family but miss police reform deadline

Joe Biden will meet the family of George Floyd on the first anniversary of his murder by police in Minneapolis – but miss his own deadline for police reform to address racial injustice.

The private meeting at the White House comes amid events in Minneapolis and beyond to mark one year since Floyd was killed when police officer Derek Chauvin knelt on his neck for more than nine minutes.

Floyd's dying words, "I can't breathe", became a rallying cry for an international racial justice movement and demands for radical changes to policing. But to the frustration of activists, efforts have hit a wall in Washington.

Biden dropped a campaign promise to create a national police oversight commission in his first hundred days in office, reportedly after being advised by civil rights organisations and police unions that it might cause unnecessary delays.

Instead the president told a joint session of Congress last month he wanted the George Floyd Justice in Policing Act passed by 25 May. The legislation would invest in police training, ban the use of chokeholds and establish a national database of police misconduct.

The bill has been passed by the House of Representatives but is stalled in the Senate over issues including qualified immunity, which shields law enforcement officers from being sued by victims and their families for civil rights violations. Republicans have objected to it being scrapped.

Both parties acknowledged on Monday that they will not meet Biden's self-imposed deadline but insisted they can still find common ground.

The Democratic senator Cory Booker, Republican counterpart Tim Scott and Democratic congresswoman Karen Bass said in a joint statement: "This anniversary serves as a painful reminder of why we must make meaningful change. While we are still working through our differences on key issues, we continue to make progress toward a compromise and remain optimistic about the prospects of achieving that goal."

The White House played down the disappointment at failing to meet expectations. Cedric Richmond, a senior adviser, told MSNBC: "The president called for it by the anniversary but meaningful talks are still going on and it's better to have a meaningful bill than worry about a deadline."

Biden has been criticised for his support of a 1994 crime bill that led to the incarceration of thousands of Black men and women for drugs offences. But he performed strongly with African American voters in last year's election and promised to embed racial equity in his legislative agenda.

Julian Zelizer, a professor of history and public affairs at Princeton University, told the Hill the last year pushed Biden "out of the 1990s mentality of centrism and toward a deeper understanding of institutional racism".

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